Zooming

In short

People with low vision often need to make text and images bigger. When someone zooms in to 400%, the page should rearrange so they don’t have to scroll sideways. Never block pinch-to-zoom on phones.

What is it for?

Some people need to make the text and images on a website bigger to see them clearly. Pages must support this. When a user zooms in, the content should automatically rearrange itself to fit the screen. This is often called 'reflow'. A good page will reflow so that users never have to scroll from side to side to read a single sentence. This is very important for creating a positive experience for people with low vision.

All modern browsers support zooming. It's up to developers and designers to build layouts that still work when people zoom in.

How to support it

You can easily test if your page is zoomable, using the following steps:

On a computer:

1. Hold the Ctrl key, or the Cmd key on a Mac, and press the + key.
2. Zoom to 200% (twice the normal size) and check everything is readable and usable.
3. Then zoom to 400%. Can you read everything without scrolling left and right? All information and buttons should still be visible and easy to use. Do all navigation menus and search bars work correctly?

On a mobile (known as 'pinch-to-zoom'):

1. Put two fingers on your screen, close to each other
2. Spread your fingers apart, keeping them touching the screen
3. Release at your desired zoom level

Note: This is especially important on mobile devices. The 'pinch-to-zoom' feature must never be blocked. Disabling zoom creates a major barrier for accessibility and prevents people from using a tool they may rely on.

Useful links

- Adrian Roselli - Don't Disable Zoom
- CSS-Tricks - Accessible Font Sizing, Explained
- WebAIM - Responsive Design and Reflow

Abbreviations

The full form of each abbreviation used in this document.

Cmd: Command

CSS: Cascading Style Sheets

Ctrl: Control